

Words on A Wing

A collection of writings on birds that flies you gently through time



BIRDS OF INDIA: A LITERARY ANTHOLOGY

Edited by ABDUL JAMIL URFI

Oxford

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■ By Shankkar Aiyar

Imagine silence in a narrative. Imagine absence of alibi. Imagine that awkward pause in eloquence. Imagine reading *The Jungle Book* without Darzee the tailor-bird singing the triumph of Rikki the mongoose over Nagaina the snake. Imagine literature without birds. Imagine a description of the powder room without the word "twitter". Imagine reading Jim Corbett and looking for a tiger without the guiding sounds of birds. Imagine describing confinement without the metaphor of free birds. Birds have enriched literature by providing the writer that colour, that detail needed to fashion characters and weave stories. Indeed, in the *Panchatantra*, birds symbolised both human failing and character.

Birds of India brings home that richness of text and sounds. It is an eclectic collection ranging from Rudyard Kipling to Khushwant Singh, from writings on agriculture to those on the passion of bird watching. It isn't a comprehensive listing of every bird spotted among words, it cannot be. The anthology takes you on a nostalgic trip that entertains, demystifies and informs: matriarchy is not just common in Kerala, it is prevalent among bustard quails too; the Romans held birds in high esteem and ascertained the will of the gods by feeding them; the vulture lost the feathers on its neck because of King Solomon's curse; the hoopoe got its crown as a boon from him.

Abdul Jamil Urfi travels centuries across countries, civilisations and genres to put together a travelogue that flies you gently through time. You don't have to be a bird watcher to want to read this but you might turn into one after the read. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
2. (2)	Playing for Pizza	John Grisham	Random House
3. (10)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin
4. (3)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
5. (-)	The Alchemist	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (6)	The Age of Turbulence	Alan Greenspan	Penguin
3. (3)	In Spite of the Gods: The Strange Rise of Modern India	Edward Luce	Random House
4. (5)	We Are Like That Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India	Rama Bijapurkar	Penguin
5. (4)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cellphone: Reflections on India in the 21st Century	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
8. (-)	Animal's People	Indra Sinha	Penguin

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (11)	Buddha: A Story of Enlightenment	Deepak Chopra	HarperCollins
7. (2)	The Last Mughal	William Dalrymple	Penguin
8. (-)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost And Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin
9. (17)	When A Tree Shook Delhi: The 1984 Carnage And Its Aftermath	Manoj Mitta and H.S. Phoolka	Roli Books

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead